

FINER DETAILS Pilot survey in Ramachandrapuram village of Srikakulam district

ANDHRA PRADESH CASTE CENSUS

PLAYING THE DIVISION GAME

delivery of the state's poverty alleviation and other schemes," says minister for Backward Classes (BC) welfare C.S. Venugopal Krishna.

Jagan's move should also help the YSRCP's efforts to woo the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), who have traditionally aligned with the opposition Telugu Desam Party. Ever since he assumed office in 2019, Jagan has been mindful of pandering to caste interests. Of his five deputy CMs, B. Mutyala Naidu is an OBC. The others are from the SC, ST, OBC, minority and Kapu cohorts. He has also started 56 BC corporations with half the nominated posts going to women of these communities.

Critics dismiss these as cosmetic changes, considering the corporations have little funds (the state is facing a cash crunch after splurging on welfare schemes). Jagan hopes to deflect some of that criticism with the caste census, showcasing it as a reflection of his commitment to the social empowerment of the OBCs. "The success of this strategy hinges on the census results and the subsequent changes in reservation policies. It could reshape the political landscape and challenge established power structures [the Kappu-Kamma-Reddy paradigm]," says G. Kiran Kumar, president, All India OBC Students Association.

THE CASTE CENSUS SHOULD HELP JAGAN'S YSRCP, WHICH HAS BEEN WOOING THE OBCs, A TRADITIONAL BASE OF THE RIVAL TDP, SINCE IT CAME TO POWER IN 2019

In Andhra Pradesh, the OBCs reportedly account for more than 50 per cent of the population, with 139 sub-castes; SCs and STs make up 19 per cent and 5.6 per cent, respectively. The current reservation structure classifies OBCs into five groups: A (7 per cent), B (10 per cent), C (one per cent), D (seven per cent) and E (four per cent), taking the cumulative OBC quota to 29 per cent. This is besides the 15 per cent for SC, six per cent for ST, and 10 per cent for economically weaker sections, taking the total to 60 per cent. The state has 729 castes listed.

Rejigging quotas on the basis of the new data will ensure that no intended beneficiary of the Navaratnalu (nine welfare schemes listed in the 2019 YSRCP poll manifesto) is left out. It should also help balance existing policies and devise new ones for education and employment as needed. Already in line with the Navaratnalu, the BC, SC, ST, minority and EWS families have been given 3.2 million house titles.

The data on castes with occupations that have ceased to exist will also help the government understand how they sustain themselves, their livelihoods, and how they can be better supported. "The enumeration will help the YSRCP take over the traditional space of the TDP-Jana Sena alliance. It will also open the doors for the INDIA bloc, which has made the caste census integral to its promises," says Prof. E. Venkatesu of the School of Social Sciences, University of Hyderabad.

Analysts, though, warn of the blowback in the long run when caste consciousness increases and expectations reach unreasonable levels. "There is a cash crunch with the number of 'free' welfare schemes launched by Jagan. If more grants are handed out on the basis of the enumeration, sectors like irrigation and higher education will recede further for lack of funds," cautions historian D. Subramanyam Reddy. Others dismiss the caste count as "political rhetoric", but there's no denying it's a useful one for political parties. ■